

Taboo: Sandstone requires her children to study the ancient rituals of their mortal tribes.

Tobacco

Background Cost: 4

Tobacco is regarded by almost all Native American tribes as one of the most sacred plants. Tobacco, a mild narcotic, opens up connections between the Upper and Middle Worlds. White settlers who “discovered” and commercialized the use of tobacco as a recreational, habit-forming drug have ignored its spiritual qualities and opened up its consumers to the dangers of overindulging in its potentially harmful qualities. Like maize, tobacco spirits shun large farm production, but do visit areas where small quantities are carefully cultivated for ceremonial purposes. Tobacco freely offers himself as a conduit to the spirit realm.

Traits: Tobacco grants his children an additional dot of Perception and a dot of Gremayre.

Taboo: Tobacco requires his children to respect the original purpose of tobacco use, and to restrict its use to ceremonial occasions.

Whitewater

Background Cost: 1

Whether formed in a babbling brook or a rushing river, whitewater’s laughter pierces forests and announces her presence over long distances. She is mercurial in nature, by turns both playful and menacing. She is the symbol of self-challenge and the free spirit of the untamed wilderness.

Traits: Whitewater bestows upon her children an additional dot of Athletics and Survival. Her children also gain an additional dot of Dexterity when on or in rapidly-moving water.

Taboo: Whitewater requires that her children never pollute the waters.

Menehune

The Menehune are the fae of the Hawai’ian islands. In many ways, the Menehune are closer cousins to the Nunnehi than they are to the Kithain. Like the Nunnehi, they Menehune are cut off from the Dreaming to a greater degree than Western changelings. They can no longer gather Glamour from the dreams of mortals, and must instead gather it from nature. The Menehune also have Totem spirits and are able to travel to the spirit world.

History

The Menehune have lived on the Hawai’ian Islands for as long as humans have been there. They came with the first Polynesian settlers, who arrived between AD 500 and 700. It is believed that the first settlers were Polynesians from the Marquesas Islands, who were later conquered by the Tahitians who followed in AD 1000.

The Menehune tell tales of beings who lived on the islands before the arrival of the Polynesians and the Menehune who came with them. Legends of these spirits are rare in the prehuman history of the islands and are not spoken of in Hawai’ian myth. The Menehune believe that these spirits were mostly gone by the time humans arrived. They left little evidence of their existence, only hints and traces, and they are now completely gone. Who were these beings? Legend speaks of the Isle of Mu, which, like its counterpart in the Atlantic, sunk beneath the waves long before recorded history. Were these beings the descendants of Mu, or some other unknown and lost civilization? If any of the Menehune know, they certainly aren’t telling. Campfire tales say that much of the Menehune culture — and perhaps even their name — come from these long-vanished spirits. The Menehune of today claim their heritage from the Hawai’ians, but they acknowledge and hold sacred those who came before them: a much older, more primal dream.

Not long after the arrival of the Tahitians, a kahuna named Pa’ao introduced the *kapu* tradition of rituals and taboo that would imprint itself on Hawai’ian culture for centuries to come. Part of the *kapu* tradition was the new caste system, dividing society into strict hierarchical roles: *ali’i* (chief), *kahuna* (priest), *maka’ainana* (commoner), and *kauwa* (outcast). It is unknown whether the Menehune adopted this system from the mortals, or whether it was revealed to Pa’ao by the Menehune. Regardless, the Menehune continue to cling to this system to this very day.

Traditionally, the punishment for breaking *kapu* was death. The taboo breaker was given one chance: He could run to reach a *pu’uhonua* — a sacred place of refuge — before his hunters could reach him. Once there, he was protected by the kahunas, and anyone who pursued him into the *pu’uhonua* was killed, since they were now breaking taboo. After several days, the transgressor was permitted to leave the refuge and was treated as if nothing had ever happened. Given the dwindling numbers of Menehune, death is rarely imposed by the kahunas as the punishment for breaking taboo in modern times, though in the rare cases where it is, the run to the *pu’uhonua* is still permitted.

Along with Pa’ao came a new royal dynasty, beginning with a man named Pili. This line eventually led to Kamehameha, who would unite all of the islands into one kingdom. Before Kamehameha, each island had its own king and the islands sometimes warred with one another.

Life on the islands was in many ways a paradise. The Menehune interacted often with the humans of the islands, and they shared in one another’s bounty. The Menehune shared their magical gifts with the mortals, guaranteeing bountiful crops, and sometimes healing the sick or injured, and the humans often shared gifts of food or crafted items with the Menehune. Games and play were an important part of Hawai’ian culture: Surfing, kite flying, and dancing were common pastimes. Hula dances were often held to celebrate their sacred tales, and *lu’aus* (feasts) were thrown to celebrate all manner of affairs. Kindness and hospitality were important parts of life; they were part of *aloha*, a spirit of love that was deeply ingrained in Hawai’ian culture.